

His Name Shall Be Called Wonderful (20)

Nazarene

The gospel by Matthew, has often been referred to as, *“The Gospel of the King”*. Matthew begins his account with the record of the wise men who came from the east to Jerusalem, asking the question, *“Where is he that is born king of the Jews? For we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him”* (Matt. 2:1-2). Near the end of the book, Matthew records that, the accusation written above the Lord Jesus on His cross was, *“this is Jesus, the King of the Jews”* (Matt. 27:37).

Matthew records how that an angel appeared to Joseph in a dream and warned him to flee to Egypt, because King Herod sought to kill the young child, Jesus. After the death of Herod, Joseph was again instructed by an angel to leave Egypt, but rather than return to Judea, he took the young child, Jesus, and His mother Mary, and dwelt in Nazareth, a city of Galilee.

Matthew wrote, *“And he came and dwelt in a city called Nazareth: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophets, He shall be called a Nazarene”* (Matt. 2:23). Of the four gospel writers, only Matthew uses the name, *“Nazarene”*, in reference to the Lord Jesus.

There is no specific passage in the Old Testament Scriptures that record the words, *“he shall be called a Nazarene”*. However, there are number of Scriptures that tell us that the Messiah would be humble, rejected and despised.

Perhaps the gospel writer had in mind the words of the prophet Isaiah, who wrote concerning the Lord Jesus, *“He is despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief: and we hid as it were our faces from him; he was despised, and we esteemed him not”* (Isa. 53:3).

Philip found Nathaniel, and said to him, *“we have found him, of whom Moses in the law, and the prophets did write, Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph”*. Nathaniel responded, *“Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?”* (Jn. 1:45-46).

We do not know much of Nazareth, but from Nathaniel’s doubtful response, we can ascertain that it was a humble, obscure city, and likely of questionable reputation. He could not conceive how Jehovah’s chosen one, could come from such a despised place.

In the Garden of Gethsemane, when the mob came to take Him, He asked, *“whom seek ye?”* They answer His question by saying, *“Jesus of Nazareth”*. They spoke His name with contempt and scorn upon their lips. But they soon learned the power of that glorious name. When He responded, *“I am He”*, they went backward and fell to the ground in His holy presence.

Although Jesus of Nazareth may have been relatively obscure and unimportant to men, slighted and even despised, God the Father could say concerning Him, *“this is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased”* (Matt. 3:17).

Bartimaeus may have been physically blind, but he possessed a spiritual insight that others did not have. When he heard that Jesus of Nazareth passed by, He immediately recognized that He was the Son of David, and the only one who could give him sight (Mk. 10:46-52). Even demons understood that Jesus of Nazareth was the Holy One of God (Mk. 1:24; Luke 4:34).

Paul the apostle testified that there was a time when he thought to do many things contrary to the name of Jesus of Nazareth (Acts 26:9). Then, the Jesus whom he persecuted confronted him on the Damascus Road, and he was wonderfully and miraculously saved, and his course and destiny were altered (Acts 9:1-6).

How true of every redeemed child of God; wonderfully and miraculously saved; course and destiny altered forever, through a meeting with Jesus of Nazareth at the cross. Later, a man named Turtullus, informed the Roman Governor Felix against Paul, referring to him as “*a ringleader of the sect of the Nazarenes*” (Acts 24:5).

Jesus of Nazareth was despised by the world, but He was a man approved by God (Acts 2:22). God anointed Him with the Holy Ghost and with power and He went about doing good and healing all that were oppressed of the devil for God was with Him (Acts 10:38). Through this man is preached the forgiveness of sins: And by him all that believe are justified from all things (Acts 13:38-39).

The apostle John records that Pilate wrote a title in Hebrew and Greek and Latin and put it on the cross; “*Jesus of Nazareth the King of the Jews*”. This inscription written in the known languages of the time, announced to the nations that the Jesus of Nazareth who was despised and rejected of men, is King of kings and Lord of lords. When some objected, Pilate responded, “*What I have written, I have written*” (Jn. 19: 19-22).

*From lofty throne beyond the skies;
Into this sin filled scene;
Came He who all men would despise,
Jesus, the Nazarene.*

*By virtue of His virgin birth,
Fulfilled prophetic sign;
The Son of God came to this earth,
By miracle divine.*

*Though scorned by men, by God approved,
With every holy breath;
Still, in the Father's will He moved,
Jesus of Nazareth.*

*Forgiveness through His Name is gained
For nations, far and wide;
And through the death which He sustained,
All men are justified.*

*Upon His cross, in letters bold,
Jesus, the King of Jews,
In every tongue let it be told,
Proclaim the joyful news,*

*His is the Name above all names,
In every time and scene;
All majesty and power He claims,
Jesus the Nazarene!*

Bernie Payne